



Tide pools

A lot of rocky-shore animals spend the hours of low tide in small rock pools that stay full of seawater, so they do not need ways of surviving on the open shore. Some of these animals, such as certain sea anemones, live in these tide pools all the time. Others, including many crabs and small fish, roam widely over the flooded shore at high water to find food, then retreat to the pools when the tide goes out. A few open-water animals may also get stranded in the pools by accident.



▲ SNAKELOCKS ANEMONE

Unlike the sea anemones that live higher up the shore, the snakelocks anemone cannot retract its long tentacles and close itself up to survive on the bare rock at low tide.

POOL RESIDENTS

Many of the animals in tide pools spend their lives attached to one spot on the rock. Since they are always submerged—either by the pool water or by the high tide—they do not need ways of surviving out of the water. They include animals such as sea squirts and the snakelocks anemone, which would dry out and die if they were exposed to the air for more than a few minutes.

WOW!

Some small fish spend most of their lives in tide pools, defending them as their home territory and even breeding in them.

SAFE REFUGES

Tide pools form in rocky depressions and crevices on the shore that have no gaps in the rock to let the water out. These act like natural marine aquariums, and the water is changed every time the tide rises to cover them. Animals and seaweeds can live in these pools just as they would in the open sea. Many of the animals are hard to spot because they are so well camouflaged.

▼ ROCKY RETREAT

The crystal-clear water in this tide pool on the Hawaiian island of Oahu reveals a permanent growth of seaweeds that give shelter to small animals.

